

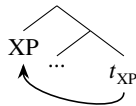
Diagnosing multidominance by focus association of ‘only’

Ka-Fai Yip and Squid Tamar-Mattis

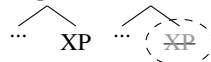
1. Introduction

This study is concerned with the nature of syntactic silence and how to diagnose it. Several constructions containing apparent gaps have been analyzed with one of three mechanisms: (i) movement with subsequent Copy Deletion (Chomsky 1995, Nunes 1995, 2004, Bošković & Nunes 2007, *i.a.*), (ii) ellipsis (Lobeck 1995, Merchant 2001, Johnson 2001, *i.a.*), and (iii) linearization of a **multidominant** structure created by Parallel Merge (Wilder 1999, Citko 2005, Gračanin-Yuksek 2007, *i.a.*), which is less discussed.

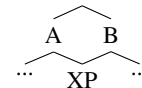
(1) a. *Movement*



b. *Ellipsis*



c. *Multidominance*



Right Node Raising (RNR) (Postal 1974, Hudson 1976, Hartmann 2000, Abels 2004, Citko 2017) is one such construction. RNR involves syntactic silence (gaps) in the first conjunct (Conj-1) in the surface word order. The element “shared” by both conjuncts is referred to as the *pivot*. They can be in different categories, such as DPs and TPs, as illustrated for English in (2) and Cantonese in (3).

(2) Right Node Raising in English

(Citko 2017:10, adapted)

- a. Mary likes __, and John also likes, [_{DP} this book].
- b. Everyone knows that __, and nobody questions if, [_{TP} the earth is round].

(3) Right Node Raising in Cantonese¹

- a. Aaming zungji __ ji Aafan m-zungji [_{DP} gobun syu].
Ming like but Fan not-like that book
‘Ming likes, but Fan dislikes, that book.’
- b. Aaming soeng __, tungmaai Aafan dou soeng, [_{TP} tingjat fei Meigwok].
Ming want and Fan also want tomorrow fly US
‘Ming wants (to), and Fan also wants (to), fly to the US tomorrow.’

How the silence in RNR is properly analyzed has been subject to debate (see Citko 2017 for overview). Competing analyses include (i) across-the-board (ATB) movement (e.g., Postal 1974, Sabbagh 2007), (ii) backward ellipsis/deletion (e.g., Wilder 1997, Hartmann 2000), and (iii) Parallel Merge/horizontal node-sharing (e.g., McCawley 1982, Wilder 1999, 2008, Bachrach & Katzir 2009, de Vries 2009, Citko 2011,

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1. Unlike English, prosodic breaks before Conj-2 and before the pivot are optional in Cantonese.

- b. *[Ni zek gau]_F ne, Aaming **zinghai** m-zungji __. (topicalization)
 this CL dog TOP Ming only not-like __
 Int.: ‘This is the only dog Ming doesn’t like.’ (ONLY: ‘This dog, Ming only doesn’t like.’)

Topicalization allows for reconstruction effects, yet such effects are absent with focus association. This contrasts with reflexive binding, where reflexives can be reconstructed to the gap position:

- (9) The pictures of **himself_i**, John_i really likes __. (topicalization)
 (10) [**Keoizigei_k** zek gau], Aaming_k hou zungji __ gaa3. (topicalization)
 3SG.self CL dog Ming very like SFP
 Lit.: ‘Himself_k’s dog, Ming_k really likes.’ (i.e., Ming_k really likes his_k own dog.) [Cantonese]

Strikingly, when the reflexive is contained in a focus associate, reconstruction becomes impossible:

- (11) a. John_i **only** likes [the pictures of **himself_i**]_F. (baseline)
 b. *[The pictures of **himself_i**]_F, John_i **only** likes __. (topicalization)
 (12) * [**Keoizigei_k** zek gau]_F, Aaming_k **zinghai** zungji __ gaa3. (topicalization)
 3SG.self CL dog Ming only like SFP
 Lit.: ‘Himself_k’s dog, Ming_k only likes.’ [Cantonese]

Across-the-board (ATB) movement, likewise, fails to license focus association. In (13–14), only in-situ association is possible.⁵ We thus obtain the generalization in (15).

- (13) (Leftward) ATB-movement bleeds focus association of *only*
 a. [Mary **only** likes THIS BOOK_F] and [John **only** dislikes THIS BOOK_F]. (baseline)
 b. *It is THIS BOOK_F that [Mary **only** likes __] and [John **only** dislikes __]. (ATB-clefting)
 cf. It is this book that [Mary likes __] and [John dislikes __].
 c. *THIS BOOK_F, [Mary **only** likes __] and [John **only** dislikes __]. (ATB-topicalization)
 cf. This book, [Mary likes __] and [John dislikes __].
 (14) (Leftward) ATB-movement bleeds focus association of *zinghai* ‘only’ [Cantonese]
 a. [Aaming **zinghai** zungji BINGO JAN_F] ji [Aafan **zinghai** toujim BINGO JAN_F]? (baseline)
 Ming only like who but Fan only hate who
 ‘Who is x such that Ming only likes x, and who is y such that Fan only hates y?’
 b. *BINGO JAN_F, [Aaming **zinghai** zungji __] ji [Aafan **zinghai** toujim __]? (ATB-top.)
 who Ming only like but Fan only hate
 Int.: ‘Which person x is such that Ming only likes x but Fan only hates x?’
 c. Bingo jan, [Aaming zungji __] ji [Aafan toujim __]? (ATB-topicalization without ‘only’)
 who Ming like but Fan hate
 ‘Which person does Ming like and Fan hate?’

- (15) Movement bleeds focus association
 An exclusive operator **cannot** associate with unpronounced copies (nor with higher copies that the exclusive operator does not c-command).

2.2. Focus association fails with ellipsis

Another cross-linguistically robust generalization is that exclusive operators cannot associate with elided material (English: Han & Romero 2004, Beaver & Clark 2008, Bassi et al. 2022, Cantonese: Cheung 2009, Yip 2025a; also Aremu 2024 for Kasem). VP ellipsis bleeds focus association, as in (16–17).

5. Unlike English, Cantonese ‘only’ may associate with in-situ *wh* (cf. Li & Law 2016, Erlewine 2025 for Mandarin).

- (16) Focus association of *only* fails in VP ellipsis (Bassi et al. 2022:817)

A. I **only** know he brought WHITE_F wine. What about you?

B1. I **only** know he brought WHITE_F wine, too. B3. I do ~~only~~ know he brought WHITE_F wine, too.

B2. *I **only** know he did ~~bring WHITE_F~~ wine, too. B4. I know he did ~~bring white~~ wine, too.

- (17) Focus association of *zinghai* ‘only’ fails in VP ellipsis [Cantonese]

a. Aaming **zinghai** wui maai SIUSYUT_F. *Aafan dou **zinghai** wui ~~{vp maai SIUSYUT_F}~~.

Ming only will buy novel Fan also only will

Int.: ‘Ming will only buy novels. Fan as well.’

b. Aaming wui **zinghai** maai SIUSYUT_F. Aafan dou wui ~~{vp zinghai maai SIUSYUT_F}~~.

Ming will only buy novel Fan also will

‘Ming will only buy novels. Fan as well.’

Notice that if ‘only’ is included in the ellipsis site, the result is grammatical. Hence, the generalization is about whether ‘only’ associates *into* an ellipsis site across a node triggering ellipsis (see also the formulation in Beaver & Clark 2008:177), as in (18).⁶

- (18) Ellipsis bleeds focus association

An exclusive operator outside an ellipsis site **cannot** associate with material inside the ellipsis site.

3. A novel argument for multidominance in RNR

We argue that the c-command requirement of focus association serves as a crucial test for *multidominance* in RNR, ruling out ATB-movement and backward ellipsis. In RNR, ‘only’ may appear in Conj-1 with an object gap, as in (19)–(21). In these cases, focus association takes place with the shared pivot object (but not, e.g., the verb in Conj-1), as evidenced by the infelicitous continuation in (19a–b).⁷ There is no restriction on the placement of ‘only’: in Conj-1, Conj-2, or in both.

- (19) Focus association of *only* in RNR

John **only** likes __, and Mary also only likes, THIS BOOK_F.

a. ... # John also likes that book.

b. ... # Mary also likes that book.

- (20) a. John **only** likes __, and Mary also likes, THIS BOOK_F.

b. John likes __, and Mary **ONLY** likes, THIS BOOK_F.⁸

- (21) Focus association of *zinghai* ‘only’ in RNR

[Cantonese]

[Aaming **zinghai** zungji __] ji [Aafan (zinghai) toujim GOBUN SYU_F].

Ming only like but Fan only hate that book

‘Ming only likes, but Fan (only) hates, *that book*.’

To satisfy the focus association constraint (6), the first (and second) ‘only’ must c-command the overt pivot pronounced at the clause-final position, as configured in (23). Only multidominance creates the required c-command relation. As illustrated in (22), the verbs in both conjuncts Parallel Merge with the same object node (Wilder 1999, Citko 2011, Grosz 2015, *i.a.*). ‘Only’ in Conj-1 (TP1), according to Wilder (1999: ex.18-21)’s definition in (24), c-commands the object node shared by both verbs.

6. While not shown here, sluicing also bleeds focus association. See Yip (2025c) for Cantonese data.

7. Vietnamese further supports this claim, where adverbial *chỉ* ‘only’ may be doubled with adfocal *mỗi* ‘only’ (Hole 2017, Erlewine 2017, Yip 2025b). There is a syntactic dependency between the two particles, assumed to be Agree by Quek & Hirsch (2017). Crucially, this dependency is preserved in RNR, as confirmed by four speakers:

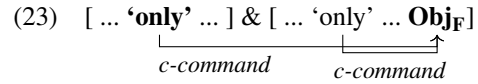
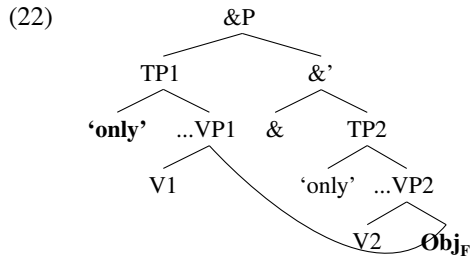
(i) [Nam **chỉ** thích __] và [Lan cũng **chỉ** thích **MỖI** CUỐN SÁCH NÀY_F].

[Vietnamese]

Nam only like and Lan also only like only CL book this

‘Nam only likes, and Lan also only likes, *this book*.’

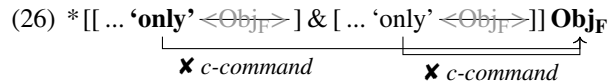
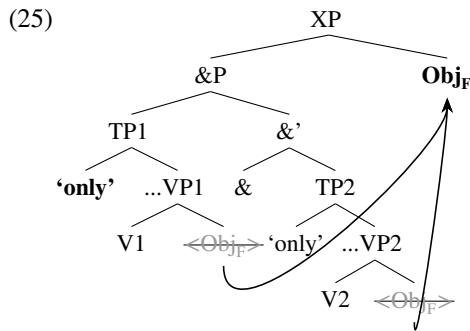
8. Stress is needed on *only* in Conj-2 due to the absence of other contrastive materials.



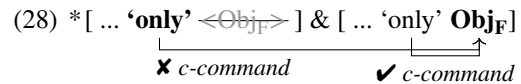
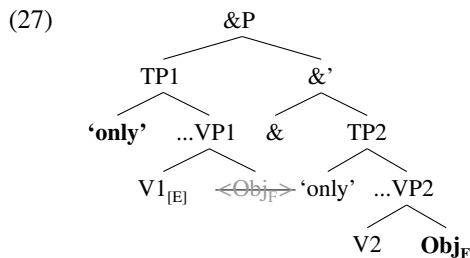
- (24)
- Sharing: α is shared by X and Y iff (i) neither of X and Y dominates the other, and (ii) both X and Y dominate α .
 - Full dominance: X fully dominates α iff X dominates α and X does not share α .
 - C-command: X c-commands α iff (i) $X \neq \alpha$, (ii) X does not *fully* dominate α , (iii) α does not dominate X, and (iv) all categories that dominate X dominate α .

Note that (24) is also used to linearize multidominant structures with the Linear Correspondence Axiom (Kayne 1994), whereby the shared node is ordered after the non-shared ones (Wilder 1999, 2008).

Now consider the alternatives. RNR has been proposed to be ATB-movement (Ross 1967, Postal 1974, 1998, Sabbagh 2007). Unfortunately, movement cannot create the correct c-command relation for focus association. In a structure like (25), both objects move to a higher position rightward of &P. There is a variant analysis with a shared pivot undergoing rightward movement (i.e., multidominance feeding movement, Citko 2005). Under either account, however, 'only' in Conj-1 (TP1) and Conj-2 (TP2) does not c-command the pronounced copy of the moved pivot, as in (26). Rather, the pivot c-commands 'only'.



RNR has also been analyzed as ellipsis or PF deletion (Wilder 1997, Hartmann 2000, Bošković 2004, Ha 2008). However, at least in the cases with focus association, ellipsis cannot provide the required c-command relation. Indeed, ellipsis does not create any new c-command relations (see §4 for further discussion on elliptical RNR). In the structure (27), two identical objects are base-generated in the two conjuncts respectively, and the first object undergoes backward deletion or ellipsis. As a result, 'only' in Conj-1 (TP1) does not c-command the pronounced object in Conj-2 (TP2), as in (26). This wrongly predicts focus association in Conj-1 to fail.



9. We do not assume the Rmerge/multidominance theory of movement (see Bachrach & Katzir 2009 for an application to RNR), because there is ample evidence for the Copy Theory of Movement from partial Copy Deletion (e.g., Bošković & Nunes 2007). Even if one takes the Rmerge view, one still needs to explain why leftward ATB-movement bleeds focus association in (13–14), but rightward ATB-movement in RNR does not.

4. A non-uniform view on RNR

While it is evident that RNR may involve multidominance, a question is whether all the RNR cases are such, that is, whether RNR is uniform. Barros & Vicente (2011) and Belk et al. (2023) argue that it is not: RNR is structurally ambiguous between an elliptical representation and a multidominant representation. The crucial diagnostics they recruit for multidominance are (i) internal readings of relational modifiers and (ii) cumulative agreement, and for ellipsis, (iii) vehicle change and (iv) morphological mismatches.¹⁰ Assuming their validity, one expects that only (i)–(ii) are compatible with focus association, but not (iii)–(iv), which enforce ellipsis and bleed the association. Below, we show that this prediction is borne out.

4.1. Multidominant RNR: focus association allowed

First, focus association is compatible with the internal reading of relational modifiers in RNR. As discussed in Jackendoff (1977), Abels (2004), Barros & Vicente (2011), and Belk et al. (2023) (see also Carlson 1987, Barker 2007), the internal reading of *same* or *different* in the pivot scopes over the subjects in both conjuncts in RNR, as exemplified in (29).

- (29) a. John likes, and Mary dislikes, the **same** books. (Internal reading)
 ⇒ Compare the set of books that John likes and the set of books that Mary dislikes: same
 b. John likes, and Mary dislikes, **different** books. (Internal reading)
 ⇒ Compare the set of books that John likes and the set of books that Mary dislikes: different

The internal readings have been utilized to motivate multidominance over ellipsis (e.g., Belk et al. 2023), since pronouncing both objects results in only the external reading (i.e., “different” from a contextually salient set) (Jackendoff 1977), and VP ellipsis also bleeds the internal reading (Abels 2004).¹¹

- (30) a. John likes **different** books, and Mary dislikes **different** books. (External reading)
 b. John likes **different** books, and Mary does too. (External reading)

The prediction is that focus association should be possible with internal readings. This is borne out in English: the sets of books liked and disliked are the same and exhaustive among John and Mary in (31). Similar patterns are also found in Cantonese, as illustrated in (32).

- (31) *There are 4 books: 1984, Animal Farm, Lord Of The Rings, Harry Potter. John only likes fantasy books: LOTR and HP. Mary, on the other hand, only dislikes fantasy books: LOTR and HP. So, you report:*
 John **only** likes, and Mary **only** dislikes, THE SAME BOOKS_F.

- (32) *You and I each have a cat. Your cat is picky and only likes a certain brand of wet cat food. My cat is not picky, but there is a particular brand that he doesn't like. You have just discovered that the brand that your cat likes is the same brand that my cat doesn't like. You say: What a coincidence!*
 ... [Cantonese]
 [Ngo zek maau **zinghai** zingji _] ji [nei zek maau **zinghai** m-zingji TUNG JAT-ZUNG
 1SG CL cat only like but 2SG CL cat only not-like same one-CL
 PAAIZI-GE GUNGUN_F] wo4!
 brand-GE can SFP
 ‘(How surprising!) You cat only likes, and my cat only dislikes, *the same brand of wet cat food!*’

Though sometimes marked, focus association is also possible with the internal reading of *different* in RNR, as facilitated by the contexts in (33) for English and (34) for Cantonese.

10. These diagnostics may interact in a systematic way given that it is possible for an elided structure to contain a multidominant structure (i.e., multidominance feeding ellipsis). See extensive discussion in Belk et al. (2023: §5), taking up the challenge raised by Larson (2012).

11. Belk et al. (2023) propose to derive the wide scope by Quantifier Raising the node-shared pivot. See Bachrach & Katzir (2009) for a Delayed Spell Out approach and Hirsch & Wagner (2015) for discussion of other quantifiers.

- (33) *There are 4 books: 1984, Animal Farm, Lord Of The Rings, Harry Potter. John and Mary are supposed to give the same books to Jim and Maggie. However, John only gave Jim LOTR and HP, but not the other two. Mary, on the other hand, only gave Maggie 1984 and AF, but not the other two. So, you report:*

%John **only** gave Jim, and Mary **only** gave Maggie, DIFFERENT BOOKS_F.

- (34) *This school has an inadequate sex education program. Male teachers only teach male students about condoms and not about IUDs. Similarly, female teachers only teach female students about IUDs but not about condoms. So you report:* [Cantonese]

[Naamlousi **zinghai** gaau naamtungwok _] ji [neoilousi **zinghai** gaau
male.teacher only teach male.student but female.teacher only teach
neoitungwok MTUNG-GE BEIJAN FONGFAAT_F].
female.student different-GE birth.control method

‘Male teachers only teach male students, and female teachers only teach female students, *different birth control methods*.’

The second test is cumulative/summative agreement in RNR (Barros & Vicente 2011, Grosz 2015, Belk et al. 2023). In (35), the verb *have* shows plural agreement jointly with the two embedded subjects in the conjuncts. Albeit speaker variation, the possibility of cumulative agreement rules out ellipsis, which wrongly predicts the pronounced auxiliary (at T) in Conj-2 to only agree with the local *singular* subject *John*. In contrast, under a multidominant analysis with a shared T head, *have* is structurally local to both embedded subjects, allowing for joint agreement and hence the plural exponent (Grosz 2015).¹²

- (35) *Several people have stolen backdoor keys, and we know who some of them are.*

%Mary discovered that Ryo_{j}, and Carla discovered that John_{r}, **have**_{j,r} stolen backdoor keys.
(Belk et al. 2023:693)

Importantly, for our consultants who accept (35), focus association is also possible, as in (36). Altogether, these facts show that focus association corroborates the multidominant structure of RNR enforced by internal readings and cumulative agreement.

- (36) *Mary discovered that Ryo stole BACKDOOR keys (but didn’t realize Ryo also stole frontdoor keys), and Carla discovered that John stole BACKDOOR keys (but didn’t realize John also stole frontdoor keys). You report:*

Mary **only** discovered that Ryo, and Carla **only** discovered that John, **have** stolen BACKDOOR_F KEYS.

4.2. Elliptical RNR: focus association disallowed

Now, let us turn to the elliptical derivation of RNR. The first diagnostic is the vehicle change effect (Ha 2008, Barros & Vicente 2011, Belk et al. 2023). This is a signature property of ellipsis (Fiengo & May 1994) and follows from its semantic identity condition (as opposed to, a strict syntactic identity condition). As in (37b), vehicle change effects are possible in RNR: a Condition C violation in Conj-1 (*she* binding *Mary*) is circumvented by vehicle change (e.g., *she* binding *her*) enabled by ellipsis.

- (37) a. I used to show **Mary_i**’s teacher interesting papers, and she_i will soon too. (VP ellipsis)
b. **She_i** used to, and I will soon, show **Mary_i**’s teacher interesting papers. (RNR)
c. **She_i** used to show {***Mary_i**’s/ ^{OK}**her_i**} teacher interesting papers, and I will soon show **Mary_i**’s teacher interesting papers. (adapted from Belk et al. 2023:705)

The prediction is that these RNR cases, derived by ellipsis, should bleed focus association of *only*. This is borne out in (38): *only* in Conj-1 cannot associate into the pivot to mean that Mary only used to show *her own teacher* (but not someone else) interesting papers.

12. Alternatively, Belk et al. (2023) resort to semantic agreement by assuming that multidominance blocks syntactic agreement. Our arguments are compatible with this treatment as well.

(38) ***She_i** **only** used to, and I will soon, show **Mary_i**'s TEACHER_F interesting papers.

Another diagnostic for ellipsis is morphological mismatches (Bošković 2004, Ha 2008, Barros & Vicente 2011, Chaves 2014, Belk et al. 2023), which follows from ellipsis not requiring strict morphosyntactic identity. In (39b), the gerund form *studying* mismatches with infinitival *to* in Conj-1 in RNR:¹³

- (39) a. Ava will soon be **studying** Oceanic languages, but Habib is not going **to**. (VP ellipsis)
 b. Habib is going **to**, and Ava will soon be, **studying** Oceanic languages. (RNR)
 c. Habib is going **to** { ***studying**/ ^{OK}**study** } Oceanic languages, and Ava will soon be **studying** Oceanic languages. (adapted from Belk et al. 2023:705)

The prediction is that RNR with morphological mismatches, by virtue of being ellipsis-derived, should bleed focus association of *only*, which is again borne out in (40). The intended reading is “the only languages Habib is going to study are Oceanic languages.”

(40)*?Habib is **only** going **to**, and Ava will soon be, **studying** OCEANIC LANGUAGES_F.

To sum up, focus association is bled in ellipsis-derived RNR, a natural consequence of the constraint (6). Ultimately, the distribution of focus association strengthens the non-uniform view on RNR.

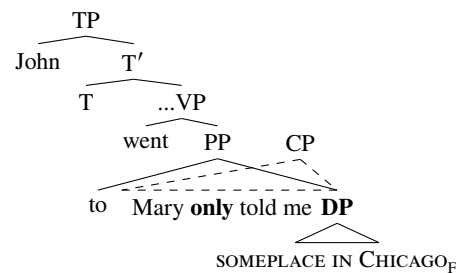
5. Multidominant structures beyond RNR

Having seen how focus association reliably distinguishes multidominant RNR from elliptical RNR, we extend this test to diagnose multidominance in other constructions. One such case is syntactic amalgams like (41) (sometimes treated as a type of parentheticals), which are argued to involve a multidominant structure (van Riemsdijk 1998, 2006, Guimarães 2004, Johnson 2013, cf. Lakoff 1974).

- (41) a. John went to, [I think it was Chicago] on Saturday. (adapted from Lakoff 1974:324)
 b. John went to, [Mary told me someplace in Chicago].
 (i.e., John went to someplace in Chicago, and that's what Mary told me)

Such multidominant analysis receives support from focus association of *only*: it may associate with the element (*someplace in Chicago*) shared with the “host clause” in (42).

- (42) Focus association in amalgams
Mary only told you John went to “someplace in Chicago”, and she didn't give you more specific information. (Mitcho Erlewine, p.c.)
 a. John went to, [Mary **only** told me SOMEPLACE IN CHICAGO_F].
 b. John went to, I think Mary **only/just** said, SOMEPLACE IN CHICAGO_F.



More recently, Yip (2025c) also applies focus association to right dislocation in East Asian languages and argues for a multidominant analysis. For space reasons, we do not discuss it further here.

6. Conclusion

To conclude, **first**, we have offered a novel diagnostic for the nature of syntactic silence in gapped constructions like Right Node Raising, namely, focus association of exclusive operators ‘only’. Drawing cross-linguistic support from English and Cantonese (and Vietnamese), we show that ‘only’ requires c-commanding the overt focus associate, which, in the configuration in RNR, calls for a **multidominance**

13. A pause **after** *be* is crucial. Otherwise, there are not necessarily morphological mismatches (i.e., ^{OK}*to be studying*).

analysis (supporting, e.g., McCawley 1982, Wilder 1999, Citko 2011, Grosz 2015). Although movement (with Copy Deletion) and ellipsis also yield gaps after linearization, they do not create new structural relations, at least at the gap position. Parallel Merge (e.g., Citko 2005), in contrast, generates the required structural relation for focus association. **Second**, we have shown that there are two derivations of RNR: multidominant RNR feeds focus association, whereas elliptical RNR bleeds it. This supports the non-uniform view of RNR (Barros & Vicente 2011, Belk et al. 2023). **Finally**, we have demonstrated that focus association is a powerful and general test for multidominance that extends beyond RNR to other constructions such as syntactic amalgams as well as right dislocation.

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